# What is Ellipsis?

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## Guiding Questions

1. Is there syntactic structure in ellipsis sites? (Ross 1969; Wasow 1972; Hardt 1993)
2. How is it silenced along the PF branch? (Saab 2008; Bennett, Elfner, & McCloskey 2019)
3. When ellipsis strands functional heads: what constraints rule out their usual unmarked forms?
   (King 1970; Bresnan, 1971; Zwicky, 1977; Kaisse, 1983, Selkirk, 1995; Potsdam 1996; Anderson 2008; Itô & Mester 2019)

(1) *The Phonological ECP*

a. I'd never go, but [$_{\omega}$ you ] [$_{\omega}$ should / could / would / will / have ] Δ.
b. [$_{\omega}$ you ] *sh' *c' *'d *'ll *'ve ] Δ.

## The Phonological Constraint

Phonological strings are organized into hierarchical and layered constituent structures of their own.
The building blocks = abstract and universal constituents along the PROSODIC HIERARCHY
(Selkirk 1984, 1986; Nespor & Vogel 1986; Hayes 1989; Itô & Mester 2007, 2009; Myrberg 2010; Elfner 2012; Kalivoda 2018)

(2) *The Prosodic Hierarchy*

$\mu$ > $\sigma$ > FT > $\omega$ > $\phi$ > $\iota$
MORA SYLLABLE FOOT WORD PHONOLOGICAL PHRASE INTONATIONAL PHRASE

Prosodic words = typically built around lexical heads (Truckenbrodt 1995; *cf.* Embick 2010)
Phonological phrases = preferentially built around every XP (Selkirk 2009; Elfner 2012; 2013)

### Elliptical Environments

Functional heads are usually parsed into words with adjacent (and syntactically related) lexical heads.
When stranded by ellipsis: they're forced to form independent words by a constraint on HEADEDNESS.
(There must be words in the phrases built around their XPs: Anderson 2008; Itô & Mester 2019; also Nespor & Vogel 1986; on the parse of FNC: Booij 1996, Peperkamp 1997, Vigaró 1999, 2003; Itô & Mester 2008, 2009; cf. Selkirk 1995; Hall 1999)

(3) *Regular Mapping*

a. FNCP → FNC$^0$ LEX$^0$
b. $\phi_{FNC}$ → $\omega$ → $\sigma_{FNC}$ $\omega_{LEX}$

(4) *Under Ellipsis*

a. FNCP → FNC$^0$ ŁEX$^0$
b. $\phi_{FNC}$ → $\omega$ → FNC

## Ellipsis in Mandar

Mandar = Austronesian language of Central Indonesia (South Sulawesi; 400,000 speakers; Jupri Talib)
Ergative-absolutive alignment; absolutive argument ("pivot") raises to a middle field subject position.
Rough word order today: absolutive DP > preverbal AUXES > verb > arguments > locative adjuncts

(5) *The Mandar Clause*

[$_{TP}$ Inggannanna **topole** pura-i [$_{voiceP}$ na-ta'gor iKaco' digena' ] ].
all guest PAST-3ABS 3ERG-greet NAME earlier

'Kacho' greeted all the guests.'

The auxiliaries license VPE, which only ever targets the *voice*P (preserving ABS agreement + every AUX)
The auxiliaries = closed class; rigidly ordered; block V-raising; mark negation, tense, modality, aspect
(On auxiliaries and VPE in Western Indonesia: Fortin 2007; Arka 2013; Van der Klok 2013, 2015; 2017, 2021; Jeoung 2020)

(6) *Verb-Phrase Ellipsis*

a. I'o ndang-o byasa pali sau a.
you NEG-2ABS usually can go PRT
'You usually can't go, eh.'

b. Iye', yau ndang-a' byasa pali Δ.
yes I NEG-1ABS usually can
'Yeah, I usually can't.'

Polar questions: highest auxiliary → c$^0$ (crossing subjects; stranding lower AUXES and ABS agreement)
Polarity ellipsis: with VERUM FOCUS on POLARITY, we see ellipsis of the TP (sparing the raised AUX in c$^0$)
(On verum focus: Hohle 1992; Gutzmann 2012; on polarity ellipsis: McCloskey 2011, 2019; Liptak 2013; Gribanova 2017)

(7) *Polarity Ellipsis*

a. Ndang i'o byasa-o pali sau?
NEG you usually-2ABS can go
'Usually can you not go?'

b. Tania, ndang Δ.
no NEG
'No, I can't.'

## Prosodically Defective Auxiliaries

Mandar has an auxiliary that's phonologically unlike the rest: it cannot form an independent word.
One consequence: it never hosts ABS agreement (which requires its host to form a prosodic word).

(8) *The Future Proclitic*

a. iCicci' ndang-i **na**-rua yari sau!
NAME NEG-3ABS FUT-ever COMPLETE go
'Chichi' will never go!'

b. Ndang iCicci' **na**-rua-i yari sau?
NEG NAME FUT-ever-3ABS COMPLETE go
'Won't Chichi' ever go?'

This constraint affects spell-out: if it's the highest AUX in a polar question, nothing visibly surfaces in c$^0$.
(On PF-constraints shaping chain reduction: Bošković 2001; Bobaljik 2002; Spyropoulos & Revithiadou 2007; Yuan 2025)

(9) *Covert Movement*

a. __ iCicci' **na**-rua-i sau?
NAME FUT-ever-3ABS go
'Will Chichi' ever go?'

b. **Rua** iCicci' ___ sau-i?
ever NAME go-3ABS
'Has Chichi' ever gone?'

This AUX can only be stranded before VPE sites when it can form a prosodic word with another AUX.
It never appears before ellipsis sites alone: for instance, under polarity ellipsis (note: ABS AGR ≠ word)

(10) *Problems with Ellipsis*

a. iCicci' na-sau-i, tapi iKaco' **ndang-na**'-i Δ.
NAME FUT-go-3ABS but NAME NEG-FUT-3ABS
'Chichi' will go, but Kacho' won't.'

b. Ma'ua-i mua' na-lao-i na [ndang / ***na** ] Δ.
say-3ABS that FUT-go-3ABS and NEG / FUT
'They said that they'd go and they [ WON'T / *'LL ].'

## Phonological Salvation

When this AUX is highest, there's a way to do Polarity Ellipsis: "pronounce the next-highest AUX or V."
This is impossible when any other AUX is highest—and multiple AUXES/main verbs can never raise to c$^0$.

(11) *Temporal Salvation*

a. Ma'ua-i mua' ndang-i na-pole, tapi **na**-pole Δ.
say-3ABS that NEG-3ABS FUT-come but FUT-come
'I thought they wouldn't come, but [ they ] WILL.

b. Ma'ua-i mua' ndang-i na-yari pole, tapi **na**-yari Δ.
say-3ABS that NEG-3ABS FUT-COMPLETE come but FUT-COMPLETE
'I thought they wouldn't come, but [ they ] WILL.

The evidence for ellipsis: constituents that cannot be elided alone go missing. (and see ABS agreement)
In the *voice*P: there are directional particles and manner adjuncts that cannot be independently elided.
(for similar arguments in work on verb-stranding ellipsis: Goldberg 2005; Manetta 2019; also Landau 2020; Simpson 2023)

(12) *Unelidable Constituents*

a. Byasa-i makkiring-**oto** **sau** na byasa to-a' makkiring.
usually-3ABS send-car over and usually also-1ABS send
'She usually sends things over by car and I usually send things too.'

b. *Na-cowa-i na-kui'-**lima** **sung** na yari-i na-kui'.
3ERG-try-3ABS 3ERG-pry-hand out and COMPLETE-3ABS 3ERG-pry
LITERALLY: 'She tried to pry it out by hand and she pried it.'

When verbs are realized beneath the future auxiliary in the pragmatic configurations that license VPE:
(and exactly and only when they're lexically identical to the verbs in the antecedent; cf. Goldberg 2005, McCloskey 2011)

(13) *Verb-Stranding Ellipsis*

a. Pura-i makkiring-**oto** **sau** na na-makkiring to-a' Δ.
PAST-3ABS send-car over and FUT-send also-1ABS

READING A: 'she sent things over by car and I'll send things too.'
READING B: 'she sent things over by car and I will [ send things over by car ] too.'

b. Melo'-i na-kui'-**lima** **sung** na na-na-kui'-i Δ.
want-3ABS 3ERG-pry-hand out and FUT-3ERG-pry-3ABS
'She wanted to pry it out by hand and she will [ pry it out by hand ].'

## Ellipsis at PF

Proposal: PF-requirements of this AUX → pronunciation of material that's present in the E-site.
(Compare escape from ellipsis sites via head-movement: Goldberg 2005, Gribanova 2013, Merchant 2018, Manetta 2019)

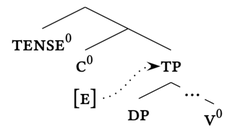
(14) [$_{CP}$ **na** [$_{TP}$ SUBJECT ___ AUX … VERB ARGUMENTS ADJUNCTS ] ]
(15) [$_{CP}$ **na** [$_{TP}$ SUBJECT ___ … VERB ARGUMENTS ADJUNCTS ] ]
(16) [$_{TP}$ SUBJECT **na** [$_{\not voiceP}$ VERB ARGUMENTS ADJUNCTS ] ]

### Schematic Account:

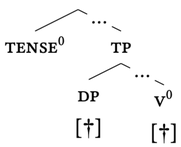
1. Ellipsis = suppression along the PF branch (Ross 1969; Merchant 2001)
2. Syntax: constituents marked for ellipsis (Toosarvandani 2009, Arregi 2010)
3. Morphology: diacritics block insertion (Saab 2008; Stigliano 2024; Arregi & Hewett 2026)
4. Factor X: forces exceptional insertion

(17) *Salvation Effects*

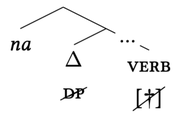
a. *Syntax*




b. *Morphology*




c. *Insertion*




## Phonological Suspension

Mandar auxiliaries form words in three contexts: before ABS agreement, before ellipsis sites, and in c$^0$:
(Prosodic words → STRESS; phonological phrases → HIGH TONES; elsewhere AUXes form words with adjacent AUXES/VERBS).

(18) *Mapping Auxiliaries*

a. Minnássa$^H$-i **ndang** na-sáu$^H$.
seem-3ABS NEG FUT-go
'She seems like she won't go.'

b. **Ndáng**$^H$-i na-sáu$^H$.
NEG-3ABS FUT-go
'She won't go.'

Before ellipsis sites: the functional projections headed by auxiliaries → visible phonological phrases.
PHONOLOGICAL ECP: the rightmost stranded auxiliary → prosodic word (heading every functional $\phi$)

(19) *Prosodic Promotion*

a. Minnássa$^H$-i **ndang rua pali** sáu$^H$.
seem-3ABS NEG ever can go
'She seems like she couldn't go.'

b. Minnassa-i$^H$ **ndang rua páli**$^H$ Δ.
seem-3ABS NEG ever can
'She seems like she couldn't.'

When this constraint can be resolved by a higher AUX: the future proclitic must be stranded alone.
When it can't: the future proclitic rescues the next AUX/VERB. (cf. Bennett, Elfner, & McCloskey 2019)

(20) *Phonological Salvation*

a. Minnassa-i$^H$ ndáng-**na**$^H$ Δ.
seem-3ABS NEG-FUT
'She seems like she won't.'

b. Minnassa-i$^H$ **na-sáu**$^H$ Δ.
seem-3ABS FUT-go
'She seems like she will.'

## Two Steps to Insertion

INSERTION: introduces exponents to morphosyntactic terminals in a parallel and global phonology.
TRADITIONAL VI = cyclic, bottom-up, node-level process of exponent selection in the morphology.
(on the wider decompositions of VI: Bye & Svenonius 2012; De Belder 2020; Kalin 2022; Hewett + Kramer 2026)

### Consequences

1. Output constraints might also BLOCK insertion (Kurisu 2001; Henderson 2012; Aissen 2017)
2. Output constraints should shape CHAIN REDUCTION (if that's VI: Bošković 2001; Saab 2008)
3. Output constraints may shape ALLOMORPH SELECTION, if the morphology can leave it unspecified.
   (Mester 1994; Perlmutter 1998; and Tranel 1996, Rubach & Booij 2001, Klein 2003, Mascaró 2004, Bonet et al. 2011…)